Suddenly, Bogey Sen spoke up, saying that in his opinion, maybe Pathania should be given the order to withdraw. Ignoring the army commander, Palit once again turned to Thapar and implored him to take command of the situation. It was obvious that if Pathania was allowed to withdraw just because the Chinese had appeared on his flanks (an eventuality that had been catered for) the defence of Kameng would collapse and with nowhere to withdraw to, 4 Infantry Division would disintegrate just as 7 Brigade had.

Palit was desperately trying to get Thapar to give a firm decision that would close the issue and put an end to all talk of withdrawal. Anant Pathania was still holding on at the other end of the telephone line as Palit went over the situation with the army chief point by point. Se-la is a strong defensive position; we have a sizeable force holding the pass; all possible encircling moves by the Chinese have been foreseen and plans exist to combat these situations; a withdrawal down a steep road towards Dirang would be un-tactical and could only result in a rout; no alternative defensive positions exist.

Thapar was beginning to see the sense of the argument and the need to take a decision. Holding up his hand to restrain Palit, he finally spoke to Bogey Sen, but instead of taking a firm stand, he started a discussion where he suggested the army commander advise Pathania to stick it out at Se-la. However, Sen had made up his mind and unless the chief gave him a clear and direct order, he was not going to budge. ‘If 4 Infantry Division can make a clean break now,’ he said, ‘it will have a chance of getting away intact.’

An incredulous Palit asked the army commander if 4 Division’s operational role was to fight the enemy at Se-la or to keep itself intact? Once again Palit asserted that there could be no question of a pullback, especially since 4 Garhwal had repulsed the initial Chinese attacks at Nuranang. Once again Thapar and Sen got into a long-winded discussion that went nowhere as Sen refused to see reason and Thapar refused to give an order, still trying to gently persuade his army commander. All this while the BGS was standing, holding the telephone with Pathania still on the line.

At this point, there was a diversion as Lieutenant General Bijji Kaul walked into the Ops Room, having arrived from Walong and Chabua.

62 BRIGADE HQ (17 NOVEMBER - AFTERNOON)